

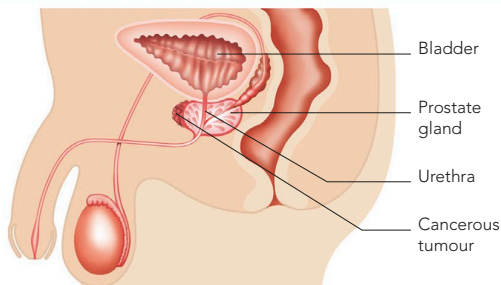
# MALE REPRODUCTIVE DISORDERS

DISORDERS AFFECTING THE EXTERNAL PARTS OF THE MALE REPRODUCTIVE TRACT ARE USUALLY APPARENT AT AN EARLY STAGE; THOSE AFFECTING INTERNAL PARTS, SUCH AS THE PROSTATE GLAND, MAY NOT BE NOTICED UNTIL LATER, WHEN SUCCESSFUL TREATMENT MAY BE HARDER TO ACHIEVE.

## PROSTATE DISORDERS

Conditions that affect the prostate gland range from inflammation and benign enlargement to serious disorders such as cancer. Prostate disorders are very common and tend to occur in the middle and later years of a man's life. Prostate cancer, although potentially life-threatening, tends to occur most commonly in elderly men, in whom it often grows slowly and may not cause symptoms. New diagnostic techniques are detecting the condition in much younger men who need treatment.

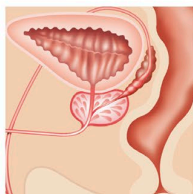
Enlargement of the prostate is extremely common and is considered part of the ageing process; most men over age 50 have it to some degree. If the enlarged gland constricts the urethra, it can cause distressing urinary symptoms, including frequent urination, delay in starting to urinate, weak flow, dribbling, and a feeling of incomplete bladder emptying. Prostatitis (see below) is a common condition, often caused by infection.



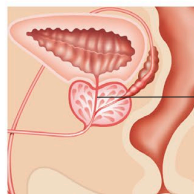
### PROSTATE CANCER

A cancerous tumour of this size on the prostate gland is unlikely to cause immediate problems, but as it grows it may press on the urethra, and may spread to other parts of the body.

#### NORMAL PROSTATE



#### ENLARGED PROSTATE



**Enlarged prostate** presses on urethra

### ENLARGED PROSTATE

A normal prostate gland fits snugly around the urethra and abuts the bladder; enlargement can squash the urethra.

## PROSTATITIS

Inflammation of the prostate gland, or prostatitis, can be acute or chronic. The acute type is less common; severe symptoms such as fever and pain in the lower back come on suddenly, but usually clear up quickly. Chronic prostatitis features longstanding but often mild symptoms that are difficult to treat, such as groin and penis pain, pain on ejaculation, blood in semen, and painful urination. Possibly caused by a bacterial infection from the urinary tract, both types are most common in men between 30 and 50 years old.

### CAUSATIVE BACTERIUM

This electron micrograph shows the bacterium *Enterococcus faecalis*, implicated in prostatitis. It is a normal, harmless inhabitant of the human gut.

